People join Freemasonry for many different reasons, but among the benefits reported of membership are fun, enjoyment, making new friends and a sense of personal achievement and satisfaction.

This thread includes a series of positive activities a Lodge can undertake to help a member to grow in his satisfaction, enjoyment and – therefore – commitment, as well as preventive activities, to respond to any signs of dissatisfaction or disengagement.

It also considers the role of clubs and societies beyond the Lodge and how they can enhance a member's experience of Freemasonry and increase the sense of fun and enjoyment.

WHY DO WE NEED TO FOCUS ON MEMBER SATISFACTION?

- Completing the degree ceremonies are only the beginning of Freemasonry, and of a membership experience that we hope will last for many years.
- How a Lodge looks after and nurtures each member will determine whether their membership will be long and happy and the extent to which they will be involved in the Lodge and committed as a Freemason.
- A major cause of dissatisfaction and resignation arises from people issues such as personality clashes, decisions (or the way they are made), from being overlooked or not being treated as one feels one ought.
- Another is when a Lodge does not recognise or respond to a member's needs, or when they perceive it does not offer them anything of value. Lodges which, during the Covid-19 pandemic, did not engage with members and offer them value for their membership (for example via online social and educational gatherings, buddy systems, etc) have found an increase in member "detachment" and resignations.
- Every member's circumstances, interests and needs will change during their membership. If a member feels the Lodge is not engaging with them, understanding what they currently want or is neglecting their needs, they may resign.
- Any resignation is a sad loss to the Lodge. Most that arise from dissatisfaction are avoidable through careful management of the Lodge and its people issues.
- Understanding and looking after the interests of each member as an individual, with their own needs and characteristics, balanced against the needs of all members and the Lodge itself, will normally avoid such dissatisfaction and minimise resignations.
- A Lodge with dissatisfied, disengaged or neglected members will have more resignations than one with satisfied and engaged members, prompting a decline in overall membership and eventually in the health and viability of the Lodge.

WHAT A LODGE CAN DO

- Build a Lodge culture with a nurturing approach, or "continued mentoring" (see "Personal learning"), that considers the needs of all members and treats all members as they would wish to be treated themselves.
- Contact all members regularly, especially those who do not or cannot attend Lodge meetings.
- Increase contact during long breaks between Lodge meetings.
- Use varied methods, including a buddy system, birthday cards, phone calls, email Lodge newsletters, social media (eg, Lodge Facebook and WhatsApp groups) and online video calls (eg, Facetime, Skype, Zoom).
- Find ways to involve every member in the life of the Lodge, through formal or informal roles and contributions suited to them, to increase their sense of belonging, interest and commitment.
- By their conduct the senior members set the tone of the Lodge. Other members follow their example.
- Seniority brings with it a responsibility to lead by example, to set high standards of behaviour and to demonstrate the essential characteristics of a Freemason; integrity, friendship, respect and charity.
- All brethren are reminded of the Board of General Purposes' statement on standards and values and of the expectation to show respect for the dignity and privacy of individuals.
- Be alert to conduct that is contrary to Freemasonry's principles, inappropriate behaviour and discouraging or negative exchanges, all of which undermine the interest and confidence of members and the harmony and health of the Lodge.
- Seek the advice or assistance of the Lodge's Visiting or Liaison Officer or another respected Freemason if, as a Lodge, you are unable to manage any poor conduct of any senior members.
- Plan meetings to be enjoyable, interesting and informative, with a good atmosphere and good ritual, to meet the expectations of members and to assist their self-improvement.
- Encourage members to undertake regular learning about Freemasonry, using Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and other reliable sources.
- Ensure administrative business and activities are planned in advance and conducted in the minimum time required. Working members are accustomed to business meetings being well prepared, conducted efficiently, free of distractions or irrelevance. They expect the same of Lodge business.
- Encourage members to deliver ritual to the best of their ability, to create a good and meaningful experience for candidates, members and visitors.
- Except on occasions when protocol dictates (such as official visits by rulers) encourage those members not in office to sit in different places with different people in the Lodge Room and at the Festive Board.
- Review Lodge traditions to confirm whether they are still relevant and serve the Lodge well. Change or evolve any traditions that might harm the future health of the Lodge.
- Consider new approaches that enhance meetings without losing dignity or those Lodge traditions that are worth keeping.
- Aim for meetings that are attractive and worthwhile, that add value to members' lives and help to maintain their interest and commitment, and so improve attendance and retention.

- Monitor attendance to identify early signs of dissatisfaction or difficulty. Agree as a Lodge how to respond and who will take action (See "Tracking attendance and apologies").
- Maintain contact with those members who are not able to attend as often as they would like, to retain their interest, support and – ultimately – their membership.
- "Engage with non-attending Members" looks at the warning signs for a possible resignation, how that can be averted and what actions can be taken in the event that a member does resign.
- Monitor the number of members joining and the number leaving over a rolling five-year period, to see if the Lodge is growing or declining.

THE ROLE OF CLUBS AND ASSOCIATIONS IN FREEMASONRY

- Although we join Freemasonry through one Lodge, once a member there are many other groups, clubs and associations that can enhance a member's enjoyment and satisfaction.
- The membership criteria for Light Blues Clubs (LBCs), sometimes called New & Young Masons Clubs (N&YMCs), vary from club to club. They tend to be for Freemasons who have not achieved Provincial rank and / or those who are under a certain age.
- They are organised at Metropolitan / Provincial / District levels and are supported by UGLE.
- They tend to be self-managing, under a constitution approved by the Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Master and adopted by the members, with a senior member of the Province appointed to oversee and guide them.
- Although each club's specific objectives vary, they all tend to offer social and educational activities beyond the Lodge.
- Therefore, they enhance a member's experience of Freemasonry, widen their circle of friends, and help them build networks that will probably continue for many years.
- For brethren joining Lodges that have few others of their age and experience, a Light Blues Club can complement what they receive in their Lodge and make all the difference between overall satisfaction or dissatisfaction.
- Freemasons have formed other types of clubs and associations, to enhance member enjoyment and satisfaction. The following are just some examples of broad categories:
  - Lodge Associations, comprising Lodges that share a common interest such as links to the armed or emergency services, schools, professions, youth organisations, etc.
  - Member Associations, comprising individual Freemasons who share a common interest such as a particular sport, music, caravanning, etc.
  - Masters' Associations, comprising those who served as Master in a particular year or locality.
  - Research societies, comprising members who wish to research Freemasonry, its history and development.
  - Provincial clubs and societies, being member associations in a particular Province.
- In addition, many members get involved in social media such as Twitter and Facebook groups, connect with members and non-members and share their enthusiasm for Freemasonry.

FINALLY

Lodges can monitor satisfaction in a structured way, using satisfaction or engagement surveys and by monitoring attendance and early warning signs of possible resignations.

Ultimately, members who continue to enjoy Freemasonry, and derive satisfaction from it as their needs and interests change and develop, will remain in membership. Those who find Freemasonry does not provide them with value will leave.

FREEMASONRY'S STANDARDS AND VALUES

In a report adopted on 11th March 2015, the Board of General Purposes stated that:

> *"The Board is concerned at the apparent increase in the number of disciplinary cases coming before those Masonic authorities charged with the duty of dealing with such matters. Freemasonry is above all a moral organisation, founded on the principles of Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth – or, as it could more familiarly be put in the language of today, kindness; charity and generosity; and integrity and honesty. Those principles – if they are to mean anything – clearly require the maintenance of the highest standards of behaviour by Freemasons in both public and private life. Whilst it is doubtless the case that the standard of conduct among Freemasons remains generally very high, the Board considers it appropriate to reiterate this obvious truth."*
>
> *"Not only is the conduct required of all Freemasons implicit in all that we do, but it has been set out expressly in writing on several occasions. For example, in June 1987 the Grand Lodge adopted the paragraph reprinted annually in Information for the Guidance of Members of the Craft under the heading "Freemasonry and Society", which concludes with the words, "The principles of the Craft make it clear to [the new Initiate] that his duty as a Freemason does not conflict with his duty as a citizen, but reinforces it." In September 1989, Rule 179 of the Book of Constitutions was amended to make explicit what had always been implicit: "As a citizen every Freemason has a duty not to engage in conduct which is contrary to the law of the land. As a Freemason he also has a duty not to engage in activity which may bring Freemasonry into disrepute." It cannot be too clearly stated that such duty does not extend only to matters regulated by the criminal courts but also covers enactments dealing, inter alia, with discrimination and health and safety, as well as those codes of conduct which cover matters such as disclosure of interests."*
>
> *"The principles of Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth also carry with them the notion of tolerance. Whilst this, of course, principally speaks to relations with and respect for others, regrettably there are from time to time instances of one Brother pursuing a grievance against another Brother or group of Brethren in so single-minded a manner that, however well-founded some aspect of his grievance may originally have been, all sense of proportion has been lost and his actions have crossed the line between what is reasonable and what is not, so that they have become vexatious and wholly unreasonable. We are urged in our ritual to drop a tear of sympathy over the failings of a Brother. Those words emphatically do not require Freemasons to condone lapses in standards by their fellow Freemasons, but they do require them to be proportionate in their response to such lapses, so that a Brother who signally fails to exercise a due sense of proportion, in the absence of circumstances which might justify such conduct, may himself be guilty of a significant lapse from Masonic standards of behaviour."*

Learning about Freemasonry, developing an understanding of it and taking part is central to our enjoyment of it. New members in particular have a need for learning and these needs fall into two parts.

1. What Freemasonry wants or expects them to learn, so that they can participate.
2. What they wish to learn about Freemasonry, to satisfy their own interests and motives for joining.

Experienced members also find that at different times in their membership they need to learn new things, especially as they approach the chair, become a Past Master, take on continuing office in a Lodge and, perhaps, become Metropolitan / Provincial / District or Grand Officers.

This document offers guidance for Lodges, to help them guide a new and existing member's learning in those aspects that Freemasonry wants or expects them to learn.

WHY LEARNING ABOUT FREEMASONRY IS SO IMPORTANT

- In recent surveys, new members expressed concern that there were not enough opportunities to learn about Freemasonry in their Lodges.
- In some cases this resulted in dissatisfaction, frustration and eventually to resignation.
- Those newer members who report satisfaction with the learning they receive about Freemasonry also tend to report greater satisfaction with and commitment to Freemasonry.
- Freemasons who have a good understanding of the Craft and their Lodge – of what we do, why we do it and how we do it – are better equipped to help their Lodges sustain their long-term future.

THE LODGE'S ROLE IN HELPING MEMBERS LEARN

- Many, but not all, members are self-motivated to learn about Freemasonry using their own resources and searches. Some started learning before they discussed possible membership.
- Personal Mentors can assist and encourage such self-motivated learning by following the guidance in "Personal Learning."
- It is important that Lodges guide members' learning from the earliest stages, to help them make sense of and understand what would otherwise be very peculiar and confusing experiences.
- This process can go hand-in-hand with mentoring, which is a different yet related process.
- Mentoring helps a new member to settle into the Lodge and into Freemasonry, and to progress in stages. It provides personal contact, support and encouragement.
- Guided learning is concerned with helping members learn about Freemasonry itself, so that they can understand it better, participate and gain more satisfaction.
- Guided learning may be offered or supported by the Personal Mentor, if they have the knowledge and experience required.
- In some Lodges it is offered or supported by a Lodge Preceptor, or by another member with a good understanding of the many aspects of the Lodge and of Freemasonry and with an empathy for and good rapport with new members.
- Some long-standing members of a Lodge may have forgotten what it is like to be a new Freemason, may take for granted their own learning and not appreciate how difficult it can be to develop an understanding of Freemasonry.

- Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, is a very good start point for finding materials to use when educating members.

PREPARING FOR THE SECOND AND THIRD DEGREES

- A particular form of guided learning is helping a new member prepare for taking their second and third degrees.
- Start this by explaining that, following Initiation the new Freemason takes two further degrees, each of which conveys defined aspects of Freemasonry's precepts.
- Traditionally, before a working Mason could advance to the next degree, he would be tested on his competence in the current one.
- As speculative Freemasons, we continue this idea by asking candidates for the second and third degree to learn small pieces of ritual which comprise test "questions leading from the first to the second degree."
- For the Personal Mentor and Lodge Preceptor, this gives an opportunity to explain more about the meaning of each degree and its symbols.
- Once the new member understands what he is being asked to do and why, provide him with the words to the questions and follow the guidance in "Learning ritual" to help him learn.

TOPICS FOR A LODGE'S LEARNING PROGRAMME

- "Understanding" contains a list of information that a new Freemason will find helpful.
- The following are examples of topics that could form the basis of a learning programme for all members within a Lodge:
    - Understanding each degree ceremony (eg, its meaning, signs, tokens and words).
    - The symbols of Craft Freemasonry
    - The festive board, what we do and why
    - The history of the Lodge, including its practices and traditions
    - The offices in the Lodge, their duties and progression
    - The structure of Freemasonry in England & Wales
    - Regalia worn by Lodge members, including Provincial and Grand Officers
    - Wearing regalia, including collars and breast jewels
    - Personal and Lodge regalia
    - Freemasonry and its protocols
    - Forms of address in the Lodge, at the festive board and informally / socially
    - Visiting other Lodges
    - Practices at the festive board, including proposing and responding to toasts, firing, etc
    - Making a speech
    - How to learn and deliver the ritual
    - Contributing to the life of the Lodge
    - The Royal Arch and other Orders
    - Opportunities to be involved in the management of the Lodge.
- It is essential that anything delivered is accurate and up to date. Inaccurate information results in confusion and perpetuates myths. Sources should be checked before any new material is delivered.
- Sources for information include Solomon, the Members' Pathway Suggested Reading List, local guidance documents from your Province and your Lodge history.

- Further guidance on preparing a learning programme can be found in Solomon, especially in the area "Support and Promote Learning" and the sub-sections, "Introducing learning and development" and "Supporting learning and development".
- A special topic in its own right is "Learning ritual" and how to deliver it. Fewer people today know about rote learning, but thankfully we know more about how people learn.
- If any learning is to be delivered well, it has to be planned for and organised.

DELIVERING A LODGE EDUCATION PROGRAMME

- The topics above can be delivered to new members in a number of forms, including:
    - By an experienced member when accompanying a new member when the Lodge works a ceremony in a higher degree.
    - At a Lodge of Instruction.
    - At a study circle.
    - As a "nugget" during a Lodge meeting.
    - When helping someone to learn a piece of ritual.
    - Talks and seminars delivered by Provincial and other speakers.
    - Events organised by New and Young Masons Clubs.
- To save "reinventing the wheel", Lodge members who deliver this material could share their notes with each other as well as with the new members.
- Whenever delivering any of the above material, give new members the opportunity to ask questions. Interactive learning, in which the new member is actively engaged, is far easier to remember than passive learning, in which members are simply expected to absorb information.

WHAT NEXT?

Guided learning addresses what Freemasonry and the Lodge wants a member to learn. This is especially the case with new members, but not exclusively so. At other stages, such as when going into or coming out of the chair or when becoming a Provincial officer, Freemasonry expects members to learn new things that should not be assumed by more experienced members.

"Personal learning" addresses what the member wants to learn about Freemasonry.

Those supporting a member's learning are advised to provide a balance between satisfying both Freemasonry's need for guided learning and the member's need for personal learning.

LEARNING RITUAL

- *Learning ritual and delivering it well makes a big difference to our enjoyment of Freemasonry* and our meetings.
- *Not everyone wishes to learn ritual.* As a minimum, we ask new members to learn the questions and answers leading from one degree to another.
- *If a member does not wish to learn anything more than these, they can still be a member*, make a useful contribution to the Lodge and gain a lot of satisfaction and personal growth by doing so.
- *Few people are practised in rote learning today*, compared with earlier generations.
- Therefore, *new members will need plenty of advance notice, guidance and personal support*.
- Despite some claims that, "*Younger Freemasons won't learn ritual*", many Lodges have found that, *providing advance notice and assistance is offered, many younger, working Freemasons, enjoy the challenge and satisfaction that comes from learning and delivering ritual*.
- There are several books on learning techniques now available, but new members may find the following guidance helpful:
    - *Start learning three to six months before you are expected to deliver the ritual.*
    - *Allocate time each day to learning and use "committed time"; opportunities when you are doing something else but can attend to sound (eg, when travelling).*
    - *Start by reading the text over and over, initially silently "in your head."*
    - *Research words you don't understand and ask your Personal Mentor for clarification.*
    - *Continue by reading the words out loud, again over and over.*
    - *Then ask your personal mentor to check your phrasing, or use of punctuation, and pronunciation.*
    - *When you know you are expressing the words and their sentences correctly, record yourself or another member reading the ritual.*
    - *Play this recording repeatedly each day.*
    - *As you become more familiar with the words and their sound, test your ability to repeat passages by saying them out loud without reading the book or listening to the recording.*
    - *Begin by saying one sentence out loud and when you have learned that, add another, and then another.*
    - *Gradually increase the length of the passage you recite from memory.*
    - *Once you are at this stage, you could ask someone else to hold the book for you as you recite the passages.*
    - *Ask them not to interrupt you but to let you know where you went wrong when you had finished.*
    - *Note: if you ask someone who is not a Freemason to help in this way, be careful not to disclose to them any of the secrets covered by your obligations (ie, signs, tokens and words).*
    - *Repeat this until you can recite the whole passage.*
    - *Practice delivering your ritual in your Lodge meeting room (or other large space) with only one other person, such as your Personal Mentor or Lodge Preceptor, present.*
    - *Attend a Lodge of Instruction to deliver the piece to a group in a helpful environment.*

Curiosity and a desire to learn "something" underpins many people's reasons for wanting to become a Freemason. Enquirers in particular often cite curiosity as a motive for joining in its own right (see "Motives for joining Freemasonry"). This quest for learning can continue throughout a Freemason's membership.

Our research tells us that members expect their Lodges to help them satisfy these personal learning needs. Indeed, we know that when Lodges don't do this, members can become frustrated, dissatisfied and leave.

As well as Lodges guiding members through what Freemasonry wants them to learn (see "Guided learning"), the most successful Lodges provide direct support for this personal learning, via the mentoring process.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- Anyone new to Freemasonry will have lots of questions and seek a range of information.
- Do your best to satisfy rather than squash their quest for information while advising them to avoid seeking information about the ceremonies they are yet to go through.
- If the Lodge does not satisfy such curiosity and enquiry, they may turn to sources that are not credible or reliable, resulting in misunderstanding, confusion and the continuation of unhelpful myths.
- Refer them to Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and especially the section, "Seek & learn: About Freemasonry".
- Arrange for the Lodge Mentor to appoint a Personal Mentor who can help them.
- Ask Personal Mentors to monitor curiosity and questions to identify personal learning needs.
- Build common requests into the Lodge learning programme (see "Guided Learning").
- Encourage Personal Mentors to be assiduous in their activities and support them in their role.
- As a Lodge, monitor and record mentoring activities and their impact.
- Review the success of Mentoring and general Lodge health by monitoring attendance and levels of involvement, as well as members' sense of belonging and levels of satisfaction.

MENTORING ROLES

- Mentoring involves a "wise and experienced" member supporting the particular or individual needs of another member.
- Mentoring is not instruction in what we want new members to learn. That is covered by "Guided Learning". It is based on a one-to-one relationship of trust and understanding.
- The Lodge Mentor is a co-ordinator for the mentoring process, not the mentor to everyone else.
- Identify the members of the Lodge who are best qualified to be Lodge Mentor, by reference to the "Role profile for Lodge Mentors".
- If they are effective in their role, create consistency and continuity by keeping a Lodge Mentor in position for three to five years.
- The Lodge Mentor selects Personal Mentors suited to each new member, in consultation with their sponsors (see "Role profile for Personal Mentors"), and co-ordinates and supports their work.
- Lodge Mentors are supported by their Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Mentor, according to the local mentoring structure.

MENTORING AND PERSONAL LEARNING

- At all stages in our development in Freemasonry we can benefit from a Personal Mentor.
- However, the mentor themself may change as we develops and as our needs change.
- Mentoring is not haphazard, impromptu or casual.
- It is planned around identified and agreed needs under the headings of information, personal contact and one-to-one support.
- Mentoring is most active with new members but continues as "light touch" or "continued" mentoring for members as they meet new challenges (eg, progressive office, learning ritual, election as Master, being a Past Master, administrative roles, Metropolitan / Provincial / District rank).
- Only accept the role as a Personal Mentor if you can devote time to the members you are assigned.
- As a Personal Mentor, build good relationships to become a good friend and trusted counsellor.
- Recognise the individuality of members and, as their interests and personal learning needs evolve, encourage them to develop their own strengths and individual contributions to the Lodge and elsewhere.
- Protect members you support from undue pressure to accept any role or office or deliver any ritual before they are ready, or to join the progression to become Master when they don't wish.
- Value all strengths and contributions, and not just the traditional Lodge roles and offices, so that all members have the opportunity to play a part in the life of the Lodge irrespective of their rank or status.
- Continue to review a member's need for information as he develops, the personal contact he wants and the level of support that he needs to help him to achieve his potential within Freemasonry.
- Members who are happy with their Lodge, have their needs for personal learning satisfied and who are comfortable and satisfied as Freemasons, will – through their infectious enthusiasm – tend to attract visitors and new members.

OTHER ORDERS IN FREEMASONRY

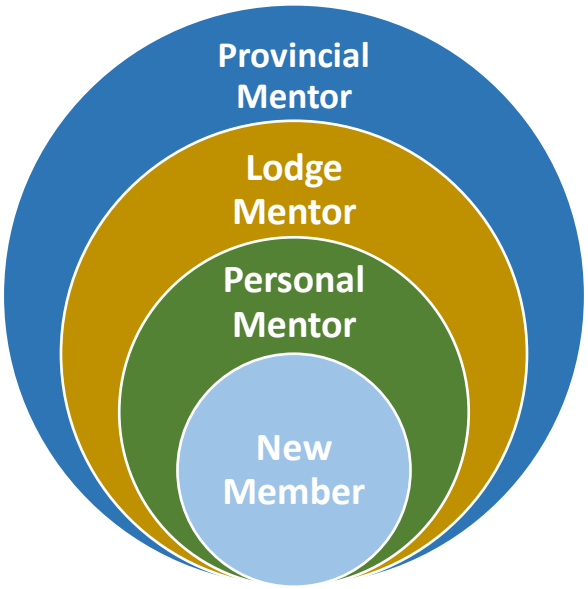
- One particular form of personal learning is to join other Orders in Freemasonry.
- Chief among these is the Royal Arch, which is the completion of the journey begun with Initiation and therefore the natural continuation from the three degrees of the Craft.
- All Master Masons are encouraged to complete their journey in "pure Antient Masonry" by being Exalted into the Royal Arch.
- The timing of their joining should suit their own understanding of the Craft, personal circumstances and emerging interest in Freemasonry.
- Members of the Royal Arch tend to remain active Freemasons for longer than those who do not complete that journey.
- A good proportion of Royal Arch Companions go on to join other Orders and Degrees.
- This suggests that the Royal Arch, and membership of other Orders, can enhance interest and help retain lasting memberships of the Craft.
- Personal Mentors can help members decide when it is appropriate for them to join the Royal Arch and can protect them from overenthusiastic if well-intentioned "recruiters".

LOCAL MENTORING STRUCTURES

A planned and structured approach to mentoring involves the following individuals:

1. The candidate or member being mentored
2. Their Personal Mentor
3. The Lodge Mentor
4. The Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Mentor.

The person being mentored should be at the centre of the mentoring process and their needs for information, personal support and one-to-one contact should drive the support they receive.



IN THE LODGE

The Master of a Lodge will appoint and invest the Lodge Mentor on the day of their Installation. The Lodge Mentor then creates and manages the mentoring process within the Lodge. They assign Personal Mentors to each candidate and new member. In doing so they consider the relationship the new member has with other members of the Lodge, their experience of Freemasonry and the match between their personal skills and qualities and those desirable in an effective mentor.

Where appropriate and possible, one of the candidate's / new member's sponsors might be his Personal Mentor.

Once assigned, a Personal Mentor will undertake the mentoring process, taking advice from the Lodge Mentor. Personal Mentors are the ones who provide the one-to-one service to new members. While there may be times when the Lodge Mentor might also act as a Personal Mentor, their first priority is to see that the mentoring process is effective for all new members of the Lodge.

The Lodge Mentor will monitor the progress of each new member and the mentoring that they receive. If changes are thought to be necessary, they will manage the process.

IN THE METROPOLITAN / PROVINCIAL / DISTRICT GRAND LODGE

Lodge Mentors are supported by their Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Mentor.

The Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Mentor promotes mentoring good practice and assists, guides and supports Lodge Mentors to help them be effective. The tools and techniques they employ might include:

1. Production of local guidance and other materials
2. Talks in Lodges
3. Regular meetings of Lodge Mentors
4. Training workshops
5. Visits to Lodges
6. One-to-one coaching.

The Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Mentor also monitors mentoring across their Lodges and reports on its effectiveness and results to their executive.

They will work closely with the Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Membership Officer to ensure that they have a coherent membership development strategy and to provide support to Lodge Membership Officers and Lodge Mentor.

The Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Master will define the particular reporting structure locally.

Discover more about Freemasonry and continue the journey you started in the Craft to complete the story.

FROM INITIATION TO EXALTATION

- Every Master Mason is encouraged to continue their journey from Initiation in the Craft to Exaltation in the Royal Arch.
- When the Antient and Modern Grand Lodges came together to form the United Grand Lodge of England (UGLE) in 1813, they declared that "Pure Antient Masonry" consists of three degrees – the Entered Apprentice, the Fellow Craft, and the Master Mason *including the Royal Arch*.
- This declaration still stands at the front of our Book of Constitutions and means there are four parts to a Freemason's journey.
- For historical reasons, the first three are governed by UGLE, while the Royal Arch is governed by the Supreme Grand Chapter of England (SGC).
- In real terms, UGLE and SGC are one organisation.
- Because of this link, our Grand Master automatically serves as the First Grand Principal in the Royal Arch, and many other senior roles are also shared.
- This connection makes English Freemasonry unique around the world and represents an important part of our history and heritage.

DISCOVER MORE

- Whether you have just been Raised as a Master Mason of have been so for some time, you probably have questions such as:
    - What is the next part of the story?
    - How do I discover the secrets that were lost?
    - What does it all mean?
- You may also be wondering how to enjoy more of what Freemasonry has to offer and how to expand your experience, understanding and connections beyond your Craft Lodge.
- The Royal Arch provides answers to these questions and is where you will discover more.

CONTINUE THE JOURNEY

- When you became an Entered Apprentice Freemason you were placed in the North-East corner of the Lodge to represent the foundation stone of a new building.
- You were also encouraged to *raise a superstructure perfect in all its parts and honourable to the builder*.
- Your Initiation was the beginning of a lifelong journey in which you will discover more about who that builder is.
- The degrees you pass through on this journey contain allegorical lessons that aim to help you live a better life in harmony with others, and serve as an example that benefits society.

- Even though the world has changed much since the Eighteenth Century when these stories and allegories were first conceived, the principles involved are just as important now as they ever were.

FOLLOW THE CLUES

- By the time you became a Master Mason you will have learned a great deal and made much personal progress.
- You will also have learned that the journey is not finished because the genuine secrets of a Master Mason remain lost.
- This implies there is more to learn.
- In the Royal Arch, you will complete this journey and recover the true secrets of a Master Mason through a spectacular, colourful, and dramatic ceremony you will remember forever.
- However, the 'genuine secrets' you recover in the Royal Arch are not what you think they are. They are even better.

ENJOY COMPANIONSHIP

- You will also learn the important lessons of companionship and collaboration.
- Just as the three original Grand Masters worked together to build King Solomon's temple, everything in the Royal Arch is done as part of a team.
- This emphasises the further friendship and companionship to be found within the Order, and the important value of working in harmony with others.
- In addition, what you learn as a Royal Arch Mason encourages you to act as an example to support and inspire others.

DISCOVER ANSWERS

- If you have enjoyed the three Craft Degrees, then you will be pleased to know there is still more to discover in the Royal Arch.
- You will be highly impressed by the splendour and drama in the Ceremony of Exaltation, and will learn more about the story behind the building of King Solomon's temple.
- You will also have a fantastic and enjoyable time on your journey and make new friends and Companions while doing so.
- As the journey unfolds, you will start to understand Freemasonry in a whole new way.
- Your understanding of the nature and duty of the 'builder' referred to at your Initiation will be clarified and you will begin to understand how to build the superstructure that is perfect 'in all its parts.'

FREEMASONRY IN THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY

- The journey through Pure Antient Masonry and the discoveries each person makes in the Royal Arch are very personal.
- You will discover that, even today, the stories and allegories still offer valuable lessons from which we can all learn, and which we can all enjoy.
- By applying what we learn on this journey, we can indeed become *honourable to the builder* in a way that would still be recognisable to those who first developed these messages hundreds of years ago.

THE NEXT CHAPTER – WHAT WILL I DISCOVER?

- **Answers**: Follow the clues from the Third Degree to complete the story and your personal journey in Pure Antient Masonry.
- **Companionship**: Work together with old friends and new Companions to build on and develop the principles of the Craft.
- **Splendour**: Learn more about our history in the spectacular ceremony of the "beautiful degree", which you will remember forever.
- **Yourself**: Uncover new perspectives that will support you in a personal journey of discovery.

WHEN CAN I JOIN THE ROYAL ARCH?

- You are eligible to join the Royal Arch four weeks after you have been Raised as a Master Mason.
- In the past some suggested you should wait until you have been Installed in the Chair of your Lodge before joining.
- However, this myth is based on outdated ideas and old rules that no longer apply.
- The simple answer is that you should find the most suitable Chapter and join at a time that is right for you.
- Just like in the Craft, there are many different Royal Arch Chapters, each with their own history, traditions and special features. There are also many special interest Chapters.
- So, just ask your Lodge's Royal Arch Representative for advice, or contact your Metropolitan, Provincial, or District office.
- Or just speak to anyone wearing a Royal Arch jewel. They will be pleased to help you complete your journey.

Further reading can be found here https://www.ugle.org.uk/about-us/royal-arch

And for those who are members' of the Royal Arch and looking to engage members Archway is now available here: https://b.ugle.org.uk/membership

Migration is the process of assisting members find a new Lodge when they relocate. Its purpose is to help members find new Lodges well suited to them and to enable them to continue their membership without a break in service.

Achieve this purpose involves two elements. First, an agreed system or processes operated by officers in the Lodge and beyond and, secondly, awareness in Lodges of members planning to relocate. This awareness enables the migration system to be triggered at an early point and membership continued without a break.

There is an agreed process operating between Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Lodges and operated by a designated Migration Officer. The current process is described in the document "Migration flow chart."

However, that process is to subject to change with the introduction and implementation of the Hermes system.

As part of the phase-one Hermes development, Lodge secretaries will be responsible for maintaining members' personal details, including recording address changes that will then be held on Adelphi.

This facility will be developed in Adelphi following the rollout of Hermes, so that when an address is changed and if the new address is in a different Province, it will trigger an email to the Provincial Grand Membership Officer in the destination Province, enabling him to contact the member, or forward the information to the relevant officer responsible for migration enquiries. The action and outcome would be recorded on Adelphi. A similar notification would be produced if the member was moving to a new District.

The essential point about managing migration is that Lodge officers should be aware of a member's plans to relocate and to trigger the migration process as early as possible. This increases the likelihood that the member will find a new Lodge suitable to him and continue in Freemasonry.

The Members' Pathway: *Level 3*

ENGAGE> Continued Learning and Development > *Managing Migration*

MIGRATION FLOW CHART *(prior to the launch of Hermes)*

1 ***Lodge Secretary***.
A notifiable change of a member's personal data is given to the Lodge Secretary. Current system requires him to send this information to the Provincial Office, either by post, online or email, ASAP using the approved format.

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2 ***Provincial Office (PrOff)***
Processes the Adelphi updates and considers if any further action is required in respect of Member Migration and takes appropriate action below.

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Note: The Member Migration Process is triggered at this point.

DPO = Designated Provincial Officer
(Will vary according to Province/District)

PrOff = Provincial Office
MMP = Member Migration Process

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3 ***"RESIGNATION"***
DPO is notified by PrOff to conduct exit interview for reason of Resignation. If due to moving away DPO will recommend the Member Migration process (MMP).
If the member accepts, the MMP starts.
All other reasons for Resignation should be processed

4 ***"ADDRESS CHANGE"***
If change of address is significant and likely to involve moving away, PrOff will inform the DPO to make contact with the member and recommend the Membership Migration Process.
If the member accepts, the MMP starts.

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5 Allocated 'Home' DPO finalises details with member and, via his PrOff makes contact with 'Target' DPO and passes on details required.
Both DPOs record a new MMP event in an 'Activity Register'.

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6 Target DPO then makes contact with migrating Brother, confirms the member's requirements, discusses options and passes on welcoming local information regarding the new Province.
Update the Activity Register

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7 Target DPO organises visits and introductions to potential Lodges in new Province. Transferring Brother confirms his acceptance of a new Lodge in due course and starts transfer/joining process aided by Target DPO.
Update the Activity Register

⇩

8 Transferring member joins new Lodge, settles in, and confirms his satisfaction.
Update the Activity Register

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9 Target DPO contacts the Home DPO to notify and record a successful migration with details of the members new destination lodge in the Activity Register.
Close the Activity Register record for successful migration as appropriate.
NOTE: Details of an unsuccessful migration should also be recorded.

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10 Both Provincial Offices monitor their Activity Registers to ensure all MMP events reach a satisfactory conclusion.

Additional Notes on Member Migration Process Flowchart

Step 1	The method of notifying the Provincial Office of a lodge member's amendment data varies by Province. In time it might be possible to introduce a common online form to provide a standard transmission across Provinces.
Step 2	Important Provincial Office action required to start the Member Migration Process.
DPO.	Designated Provincial Officer – this role to be allocated by each Province. E.g. Provincial Mentor.
Step 3	Exit interviews may already be conducted by a delegated officer, e.g. VGO. It is suggested the DPO would liaise accordingly. It is important the member accepts the Member Migration Process
Step 4	Similar – member to accept MMP.
Step 5	Initial contact with the Target DPO should be via the home Provincial Office to maintain protocol. Each Provincial Office will maintain an 'Activity Register' to record developments and ensure a closed loop activity. This may be incorporated into Adephi 2 at some point.
Step 6	Target DPO maintains contact with member and Home DPO
Step 7	Target DPO maintains contact with member and Home DPO. Both DPOs assist with the transfer administration.
Step 8	New Lodge welcomes their new member.
Step 9	If successful migration, both DPO's congratulate member on his transfer and updates Activity Register.
Step 10	Provincial Offices close Activity Register item and finalise entry in Adelphi.

Entering Freemasonry, and especially the ceremony of Initiation, bombards the new member's senses with a huge amount of new information.

From being asked to adjust their dress prior to the ceremony, through their admission, being asked to repeat words offered in a series of prompts and the sights they see when the blindfold is removed, may leave them feeling vulnerable, anxious and confused. By definition, it is a new and unique experience, one that will outside of most people's comfort zone.

The ceremony itself is an example of experiential learning. We learn by taking part. It stimulates different emotions in different people and by doing so it leaves a lasting impression. Little wonder that many have said, "Initiation is one of the most memorable experiences in my life."

However, experiential learning is most effective when it is followed by a period of reflection and then by our own attempts to interpret and understand what has happened.

This thread addresses how we can help the new member process their experience and develop an early understanding of what they have joined.

WHY IS EARLY INFORMATION SO IMPORTANT?

- When we are exposed to something new, our brain tries to make sense of it by drawing on previous information and experiences along with the new.
- Other than the briefing you will have previously offered (see "Briefing the candidate for Initiation"), you have little control over how a new member manages this process.
- Therefore, it is important that you offer them some appropriate information and support very soon after the ceremony, starting from when the ceremony has concluded.
- Without this, the new member may develop an inaccurate or unhelpful interpretation that takes time for others to recognise, let alone clarify.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGE MEMBERS

- In recent years, attempts to provide early information have resulted in additional letters, booklets and presentations being given to the Initiate at the end of the ceremony itself.
- These have increased the amount of new information an Initiate receives at a point when they are experiencing a range of emotions.
- Some new members have reported there being "too much at once" and wanting a chance to ask questions, engage and check their understanding.
- A different approach is for the Initiate's Personal Mentor to have some time with the new member immediately after the ceremony and for additional materials to be presented at the festive board or privately at its conclusion.
- Other Lodge members and visitors can then concentrate on welcoming the new member.

GUIDANCE FOR PERSONAL MENTORS

- Immediately after the ceremony of Initiation, take five to ten minutes alone with the new member to check their reaction to the experience, address any initial questions or concerns and reassure them that it will take them a long time to process the experience and understand what happened during the ceremony.
- Offer them a copy of "Simple explanation of the Initiation ceremony" and of the "Charge after Initiation" and explain that he can share these with their wife / partner and immediate family.
- Arrange an informal meeting with the new Freemason within a week or so of their Initiation to:
  - discuss what happened during their Initiation and what they need to know for the immediate future.
  - practise with them the sign of the degree, and any firing undertaken at the Festive Board.
  - address any questions that they may have at this point.
- Ideally this meeting will be face-to-face. However, if arranging this is impractical or it introduces an unhelpful delay, it could be online.
- See "Stewardship" for further guidance on supporting a new member.

INFORMATION USEFUL TO A NEW MEMBER

- The following are among the important topics that are useful to discuss with a new member over time, during mentoring sessions and Lodges of Instruction.
- Some of the following information will be available in locally produced resources aimed at the new member. However, it is important that they have the opportunity to discuss these with their Personal Mentor.
- It is important to cover the ground at the pace and in the order that suits them, rather than overburden them with too much information at once.
- It is best to provide the information in response to their questions, always being prepared for what they might wish to discuss.
- It is also important that the information provided is current, accurate and does not impose one member's personal views on an impressionable new member with their own needs and interests.

1. The organisation of the Lodge and duties of the Lodge officers. *(Introducing the new member to those officers at the next Lodge meeting will accelerate their sense of belonging.)*
2. A schematic layout of the Lodge Room and the seating positions of the officers.
3. The names of Lodge members, their wives or partners and their contact details.
4. A symbolic explanation of the ceremony taken most recently.
5. The ritual for the ceremony taken most recently, if available and if copyright allows.
6. The correct manner of giving signs, tokens and words for that ceremony.
7. The nature of the "secrets" of Freemasonry:
   a) as no more than the means to demonstrate a Freemason's qualifications to be present in a Lodge open in a certain degree or to be admitted to another degree.
   b) for use only in an open Lodge and not outside.
8. Leaving the Lodge during a ceremony that they are not yet qualified to attend.
9. The traditional language of the ritual and its use to convey the aims, ideals and traditions of Freemasonry within a Lodge meeting.
10. The use of today's language to explain our experience of Freemasonry in a modern and relevant context.

11. The function and content of the Lodge summons.
12. Basic etiquette in Freemasonry.
13. Titles and ranks, addressing others, preambles in Lodge and at the Festive Board.
14. The Festive Board, its structure, practices and traditions.
15. Firing at the Festive Board, history and variations.
16. Lodge rehearsals and Lodges of Instruction, their value and importance.
17. The questions leading to the next degree and the answers that he must give beforehand.
18. Learning ritual; tips and techniques, an appropriate piece to start with, being ready to deliver ritual.
19. The words for the Opening and Closing Hymns used, as well as other songs used in the meeting or at the Festive Board.
20. Inviting Guests and the responsibilities involved.
21. Booking to attend meetings, the need for submitting apologies and the consequences of late responses.
22. Visiting other Lodges; booking in, paying, what to expect and what will be expected of them.
23. Respecting the differences between Lodges, their ritual and other practices.
24. Applying the principles of Freemasonry to our everyday lives. Reference to the Charge after Initiation, which spells out the way in which we should live our lives, may help.
25. Managing commitments; their first responsibility should always be to their family, secondly to their employment, and (only) thirdly to their commitments in Freemasonry.
26. The relationship between the Craft and Royal Arch within pure Antient Freemasonry, the relationship of the other Orders and maintaining a commitment to one's Mother Lodge.

Note: The names used to refer to the Lodge's meeting place and the after-proceedings differ from Province to Province. For the sake of simplicity, they are referred to in the Members' Pathway as the Lodge Room and the Festive Board, respectively. Similarly, for ease of reading all references to Provinces should be taken to apply equally to Metropolitan and District Grand Lodges.

Asking a new member to participate in Freemasonry, the Lodge and its activities from their Initiation onwards will help them to learn and understand more about what we are, and to feel part of and more committed to the Lodge.

However, the level of participation should suit the circumstances, wishes and interests of the new member.

Indeed, there is fine line between encouraging participation and coercion.

The first has positive benefits while the second often leads to an early resignation. The distinction between the two is not always in the words or actions of the person supporting the new member, but rather in the manner in which they are conveyed and the way they are perceived by, and the effect they have on, the new.

This thread looks at how you can encourage participation in Lodge meetings, in visiting other Lodges and in social events.

PARTICIPATION IN LODGE MEETINGS

- Add the new member to the Lodges communication and social media channels, such as email distribution lists, WhatsApp groups, etc.
- You will have told the new member the dates of regular Lodge meetings during your early discussions about joining. Encourage them to add dates and times to their diary.
- Explain they should plan to arrive at least 30-minutes before the start time published on the summons, but that if family or work circumstances prevent them from doing so, they should still attend, albeit late, and will be just as welcome.
- Be alert to any issues about start times and potential clashes with work or family commitments.
- If new members do have difficulty with start times, review them and be prepared to adjust them to increase attendance.
- Help the new member make sense of the summons, the different information it contains and the implications for them.
- Point out in particular:
  - The importance of responding to a summons as soon as possible, including submitting apologies.
  - The importance of submitting meal choices and paying for meals when requested.
  - The implications of the dress code.
  - The meaning of different items of Lodge business and how the impact on the new member.
  - Whether or not they will be required to retire from the meeting while it conducts a degree that they have not yet taken.
- Accompany the new member at their early meetings, to introduce other members and regular visitors, and to answer their immediate questions.
- Help them feel comfortable during Lodge meetings by ensuring they have everything they need to participate, such as:
  - An appropriate Lodge or Metropolitan / Provincial / District tie.
  - The words to opening and closing odes, and other songs (including Grace).
  - Confidence in using signs, tokens and words, including the Sign of Fidelity during prayers.
  - The method of approving a motion, "according to the manner customarily used among Masons."
  - The method of addressing the Master and other members during an open Lodge.
- Arrange for someone to accompany them if they have to retire from the Lodge.
- Demonstrate good conduct in a Lodge and act as a role model.
- Enquire whether they would like to deliver part of the ritual at a forthcoming meeting and explain they will receive plenty of notice and help with the learning required.
- Enquire whether they would like to propose or respond to a toast at the Festive Board.

- If they have previously declined either of the above, remind them that they make subsequently offer to do so.
- At regular intervals, check how they think or feel they are progressing and whether they wish to progress at a faster or slower pace.
- Explain to them the different activities undertaken in the Lodge and the routes they can follow, or special interests they could develop.
- Enquire whether they would like to learn more about, or help with, any of these activities and make suitable arrangements with the officers involved.
- Keep in contact during breaks between Lodge meetings, especially any extended summer breaks. Research in one Province indicates that candidates who are Initiated between January and June are less likely to remain in membership than those Initiated between September and December, largely because of the reduced participation.
- Keep all of the above under review at intervals and seek the support or assistance of other members of the Lodge as necessary.

BENEFITS OF VISITING

Research undertaken by the Membership Focus Group (MFG) highlighted the benefits to new members of visiting other Lodges. It produced evidence that those new members who visit from an early stage are more likely to build their commitment to Freemasonry and remain in membership.

The benefits to the new member include:

- A chance to reflect on what the member them self may have experienced very recently
- Increased familiarisation with the ceremonies
- Opportunities to learn about Lodge practices and protocols
- An appreciation of and respect for the similarities and differences between Lodges
- A wider network of new friends, and possibly discovering existing friends who are already Freemasons
- Increased confidence
- A chance to visit a special interest or affiliation Lodge with which they might have something in common
- An opportunity to build Freemasonry into their lifestyle at a level that suits them, especially if their own Lodge meets infrequently.

GUIDANCE WHEN ACCOMPANYING A NEW MEMBER ON A LODGE VISIT

- *Encourage new members to visit and offer to attend with them*, without suggesting that visiting is required or coercing them to visit beyond their own capabilities or resources of time and money.
- *Before making a visit, explain to the new member*:
    - How to book to visit another Lodge, including local contact arrangements
    - The importance of booking by the Lodge's booking deadline
    - How to check a summons for timings, dress code, ceremonies, etc.
- *Accompany a new member on their early visits*, travelling with them if possible.
- *On arrival at the Lodge being visited,* explain:
    - How to pay for the meal
    - How to obtain EAF & FCF regalia
    - Signing in using the Tyler's Book.
- *Before the Lodge opens,* explain:
    - Seating arrangements in a Lodge
    - Singing of opening and closing odes
    - Making sure not to vote on resolutions before the Lodge
    - The procedure when retiring from a Lodge about to work in a higher degree, and returning afterwards
    - Giving greetings, if this is done in the Lodge
    - Advising them to make note of particular points they could mention if asked to respond to the visitors' toast.
- *During the Lodge*, sit with them, or seat them with another friend, and act as a role model in matters such as not speaking during ceremonies, giving salutes, etc.
- *After the Lodge has closed,* remain with the new member rather than join any procession, accompany them to the bar and the festive board, introduce them to members of the Lodge and other Freemasons at a similar stage to them.
- *At the festive board:*
    - Sit with them so that you can explain the practices of the specific Lodge and how it differs from their own.
    - Demonstrate firing, respect for the gavel and other matters of practice and protocol.
    - Remind them to remain seated during the toast to the visitors.
    - Ensure they have the words to any songs being sung.
    - Answer any questions about the various proceedings.

LODGE SOCIAL EVENTS

- "Engaging through social and community events" has much to say about the benefits of Lodge socials for attracting new members and their families.
- Lodge social events broaden the satisfaction that can be gained from Freemasonry, by bringing together members with a common bond and their families in an enjoyable environment.
- They also create opportunities for members to contribute something different to the Lodge.
- Many new members will have experienced Lodge social events as a guest when they were considering whether to apply to join.
- Encourage new members to attend their Lodge social events as often as they can, either because it is something they know they will enjoy or to support those who have arranged the event.
- Identify any planning and organisation skills that a new member could contribute towards Lodge social events.
- Encourage them to suggest ideas for other events, to broaden the range of events on offer.
- Involve partners and family members as members of social committees and as event organisers.

New Freemasons need not only information about Freemasonry, but also personal contact and support.

All members of the Lodge have a role in making the new member feel welcome and supported. However, support is especially effective when it comes from an experienced member who has built a relationship with the new member and who can tailor the support in response to an understanding of their needs and interests.

The Lodge Mentor's role is to find such an experienced member for each Initiate, appoint them as the Personal Mentor and help them in their work.

In many cases, the new member's proposer or seconder may make a good Personal Mentor. If they are not sufficiently experienced, available or well suited to the task, the Lodge Mentor may appoint someone else as Personal Mentor.

The desired end result is a new member who enjoys Freemasonry, has a growing understanding and appreciation of it and is willing to continue their membership and commitment at a level that suits and satisfies them.

WHY IS EARLY SUPPORT SO IMPORTANT?

- The ceremony of Initiation will have made an impact on the new Freemason and they will be likely to remember it for a long time.
- As people form enduring first impressions within the first ten seconds of meeting, Lodge members' behaviour towards the Initiate in the period soon after Initiation will determine whether or not they like and feel comfortable with them and even whether they wish to form lasting friendships with them.
- Any inconsiderate actions by members may create a negative impression of Freemasonry as a whole.
- In the days, weeks and months following Initiation the new Freemason will reflect on their experiences and consider whether or not their expectations have been met, exceeded or possibly disappointed.
- At this point the new Freemason is at their most vulnerable; a significant proportion of new members leave the Craft within two years of Initiation, often before becoming Master Masons.
- If the new Freemason perceives either the ceremony or the actions of Lodge members to be anything other than positive, or if their expectations are not met, they may consider terminating their membership.
- The Personal Mentor and sponsors have a small window of opportunity to respond to all early reactions, to address any concerns and to provide the support that the new Freemason needs.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGE MEMBERS

- *Remember how you felt when you first joined the Lodge,* and how you benefited from a warm welcome, a smile and kind word from an older or more experienced member.
- *Imagine yourself in the new Freemason's position.* What might help their comfort and confidence?
- *Spend time with a new member at each of their early meetings* and get to know them better.
- *Introduce them to other members and visitors.* Use their names to help them remember without embarrassment.
- *If no one is sitting with a new member, move over to keep them company*.
- *Ensure that they are not left alone*, uncertain what is happening or what they are expected to do.
- *Explain to them and show them the correct way to address others*, give signs and fire at the festive board.
- *Being new to their surroundings they cannot be held responsible for any mistakes* they may inadvertently make. It is the responsibility of those who are meant to support them to ensure they are properly briefed.
- ***Some Freemasons will settle in more quickly than others***. Continue this "intensive care" for as long as the new Freemason needs this level of support.

GUIDANCE FOR PERSONAL MENTORS

- Arrange an informal meeting with the new Freemason soon after their Initiation to:
  - discuss what happened during the Initiation and what they need to know for the immediate future.
  - practise with them the sign of the degree, and any firing undertaken at the Festive Board.
  - address any questions that they may have at this point.
- Hold this and other meetings in an environment where you can talk freely, such as in one person's home, the Lodge Rooms, in a pub or over a meal.
- Meetings at the Lodge Rooms will allow you to show them some of the elements you will be discussing.
- Attempt to understand issues from their perspective. Be patient, listen and show empathy at all times.
- Gauge their level of interest and enthusiasm and respond at that level. Avoid "force feeding" them what you think they should know and understand.
- Respond quickly to allay any misgivings, doubts or fears. Reassure and encourage them when they are anxious or lack confidence. Protect them from expectations that place them under undue pressure.
- Pass on any communications or resources provided by the Lodge and the Province. Help them to find information they want from the various materials they will have been given.
- Encourage them to register to use Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and to enrol for modules that reflect their interests, advising them not to access material beyond their current degree.
- Encourage the Lodge to plan its own learning or education programme, with assistance from the Province if required.
- As we all have different preferences for how we receive information, and different "learning styles", discuss the information the new member now wants about Freemasonry and how they would prefer to access that information.
- Examples include by personal research, supplied reading, book, website or by discussion.
- Draw on the "Understanding" thread, and locally produced guides, but proceed at their pace, not yours, and respond to their interests and curiosity, rather offer than a rigid programme.
- Arrange other meetings to suit the amount of contact they would like with you as their Personal Mentor.
- Agree the mode of contact to be used; face-to-face, by phone, email, social media or other medium.

- Form a view on how much personal support and encouragement they might need and prepare to deliver this at a level that has the most positive impact upon them.
- As informal meetings progress, involve their sponsors and other Lodge members as appropriate.
- At the end of each meeting arrange the next one rather than leave it to them to call one when needed.
- Suggest visiting other Lodges, with you or another supporter, if and when they have the time to do so.
- At Lodge meetings help them find their way between different parts of the building, between different parts of the meeting and to find appropriate seating.
- Sit with the new Freemason in the Lodge. Explain what is happening, always demonstrating correct behaviours such as obeying the gavel.
- When you both agree they are ready, arrange for them to deliver some ritual or undertake some other work in support of a Lodge meeting.
- Find ways to involve them in the Lodge that suit their availability, skills, circumstances and confidence. Make sure his contributions are valued and recognised by others in the Lodge.
- Discuss their contribution to other members' ceremonies with the Lodge's Director of Ceremonies, so that they are asked to do what is appropriate to them.
- Prepare them for the ceremonies of Passing and Raising by:
  - helping them to learn the questions leading to the degree and the answers to give in open Lodge
  - detailing the relevant adjustments to their clothing for each ceremony
  - explaining the key elements of the ceremony without disclosing anything that harms their experience
  - identifying similarities and differences between the ceremonies.
- Arrange to meet shortly after each ceremony, to help them reflect, practice signs, address questions and relate the latest ceremony with the previous ones.
- Discuss Lodge offices and the best time for them to accept office. Monitor their progression to be sure it suits their circumstance and needs and not just the Lodge's.
- Continue the above cycle, reviewing the level of support they want at intervals and making adjustments to ensure they get what they need to gain enjoyment and satisfaction from their membership.
- Look out for any discomfort or drops in interest, attendance or commitment and respond early.

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The issue of attendance at Lodge meetings, and attempts to manage it, can be an emotive one. There are some Freemasons who take the view that *'Lodge meetings must always be a high priority and that members should manage their other commitments around them'*. There are others who accept that *'individuals can vary in their commitment to Freemasonry and that it is preferable to have in membership a good people who cannot attend every meeting than not to have them at all'*. In either case, almost every Freemason will occasionally miss a Lodge meeting.

However, we know that resignation is often preceded by periods of absence, relative to the individual's normal pattern of attendance. Therefore, a break in pattern and diminishing attendance is a warning sign of possible issues, whether they relate to reduced interest, dissatisfaction or a change of personal circumstances. It makes sense for Lodges to monitor individual attendance, and to make enquiries if absences vary or increase from their normal pattern.

*With the introduction of the **Hermes** system,* Lodge secretaries will be expected to update an attendance register for each meeting. *When a Lodge member misses two consecutive meetings, an automated notification will be sent to the **Lodge Almoner** in the first instance for action to be taken.*

Regular contact with non-attending members should occur in any case, no matter how many meetings are missed or whether apologies are registered. Quite often there are undisclosed reasons for non-attendance.

The following process has been found to be helpful and involves these Officers and members working closely together:

1. Using existing systems or Hermes, the Lodge Secretary maintains a record of attendance / absence at each meeting.
2. They send a copy of the record to the Lodge Mentor & Lodge Almoner shortly after each meeting.
3. The Lodge Almoner collates the data and monitors long term patterns and trends.
4. If a member is unexpectedly absent without submitting an apology, an agreed member of the Lodge Membership Team (eg, Lodge Almoner, Lodge Mentor or Personal Mentor) contacts them by phone.
5. The purpose of the telephone contact is to enquire about the member, their health and welfare, to offer assistance if appropriate and to express how the member was missed by the brethren. It is not to express disappointment in their absence or exert pressure. The member's needs motivate the call, not any inconvenience to the Lodge.
6. If a member has missed two consecutive meetings, whether with an apology or otherwise, an agreed person contacts them by phone within seven days of the second meeting.
7. The purpose of this contact is to identify any underlying cause for the absence and in particular any emerging disinterest or concerns held by the member. Compassion and support should underpin the discussion.
8. Relevant Lodge officers can then take appropriate action to address any personal needs for support, or any underlying causes, disinterest or concerns, before they escalate beyond any possibility of resolution.
9. If an impartial third party's involvement would assist (for example if the Lodge cannot manage the issue without losing the member to Freemasonry), the relevant Lodge Officer refers the matter to the Metropolitan / Provincial / District team responsible for retrieval.
10. The Lodge Almoner, Lodge Mentor and Personal Mentor keep an overview on individual cases and overall patterns and trends in attendance.
11. They report to the Lodge Membership Team and the Lodge Committee as appropriate so that both corrective and preventative actions can be taken before the Lodge's overall attendance levels diminish, ever mindful to respect any confidentiality and privacy issues.

12. When required, overall attendance levels are submitted to the Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Lodge.

This thread describes some of the early warning signs of a potential resignation and ways to re-engage the member as a happy, valued and participating member of the Craft.

- However diligent and skilled you may be in screening applicants for your Lodge, there will always be some members who decide that Freemasonry is not for them and who resign at an early point.
- Other resignations tend to be for one or more of the following reasons:
    1. Difficulty attending because the Lodge does not suit work or family circumstances
    2. Disappointment or dissatisfaction
    3. Difficulties with another member or members
    4. A change in one or more circumstances, such as age, transport, health, family, employment, financial issues.
- In all these cases, resignations can often be anticipated in advance if the warning signs are recognised.
- If you recognise the warning signs and respond early to these circumstances, you may well avert resignations before they happen.
- If you miss the warning signs or don't take action taken and a member submits their resignation, it will be very difficult to persuade them to reverse their decision.

WARNING SIGNS

- A reduction in the pattern of attendance or participation is the key indicator of a potential resignation.
- Such changes in patterns often follow an event that may have been missed or underestimated by others, but which may have been of great significance to the member concerned.
- In some cases, personality differences or issues prompt members to leave their Lodge, although they might be content to continue in active membership of another Lodge.
- Brethren who are experiencing a change of circumstances or difficult times in their lives sometimes offer their resignation precisely when Freemasonry could be on hand to render assistance and support.
- Those who move home or make other changes to their lifestyle may consider resigning from the Lodge.
- Many who do resign are reluctant to disclose to members of the Lodge the REAL reason why they did so.
- For example, many cite a change in work or family circumstance rather than tell the Lodge that, for example, the start time for Lodge meetings does not match their lifestyle or they are not enjoying Freemasonry as much as they hoped.
- Other warning signs of a potential resignation include:
    - unwillingness to take office, commit to ritual or assist with Lodge activities
    - a lack of preparation prior to Lodge meetings or events
    - delays in paying the lodge subscription
    - not responding to telephone calls, emails or letters.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- Review and use the guidance in the Engage elements to respond to declining attendance.
- Encourage all members to be alert to the warning signs of a potential resignation.
- If warning signs are noticed, ask the Lodge member best placed to address the issue (eg, Lodge Secretary, Almoner or Mentor, or the member's Personal Mentor or sponsor) to contact the member.
- Take early action to:
  - identify the needs, concerns and expectations of any member who may be at risk of resigning
  - address those needs and concerns and provide support as far as is possible within the Lodge
  - refer the matter to the Province if the Lodge is unable to resolve the issue to mutual satisfaction.
- On receipt of a notice of resignation, report the matter to the Lodge Almoner and to the Metropolitan / Provincial / District office without delay.
- Many Metropolitan / Provincial / Districts have their own guidance for this process and the Members' Pathway materials are provided to complement and support local initiatives.
- Do not accept the resignation until:
  - the Lodge Almoner and / or others have made contact with the member
  - the Lodge has had the opportunity to invite a member to withdraw their resignation.
- "Resignation - the opportunity to reconsider" sets out how a Lodge can invite a member to withdraw their resignation.
- If the resignation is due to a decline in circumstances (such as finances or health), arrange for the Lodge Almoner to offer support to the member and their family.
- Inform those who do resign their Lodge membership that, unless they also resign from the Craft, they continue to be a Freemason and may visit Lodges as an "Unattached Freemason", subject to the rules in force at the time (see "Rules governing attendance by Unattached Freemasons").
- Accept that if the Lodge cannot retain a member, it may still be possible for the Province to retrieve them if they move to another Lodge.
- If a member resigns due to their relocation to another area, contact the Provincial office to trigger the migration process (see "Managing Migration" for details) and encourage the member to retain their membership at least until they have joined a Lodge in their new locality.
- If many members resign in a relatively short period, conduct a review of the Lodge and be willing to adapt to make the Lodge more attractive and engaging.
- In such cases, the guidance in "Lessons learned from losses" will also help.

SUGGESTED GUIDANCE FOR PROVINCIAL GRAND LODGES

- Encourage Lodge Secretaries, Lodge Almoners, Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors to recognise warning signs and take early action to identify, address and refer issues, as detailed in the section above.
- Establish a system for conducting exit interviews of those who resign from their Lodge (see "Understanding the real reasons for losses").
- Implement the migration system (see "Migration flow chart"), as approved and adopted by the Provincial Grand Masters' Forum in November 2015, to retain in the Craft any member who relocates to another area.

The Members' Pathway: *Level 3*

RETRIEVE> Understand Reasons for Losses > *Unattached Freemasons*

Once a Freemason has resigned from all of his Lodges, he is termed "unattached" and there are rules governing his rights to visit other Lodges.

However, an unattached Freemason does not need to be a permanent loss to the Craft.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- Many Unattached Freemasons are likely to have become so due to a change in their personal circumstances.
- These include relocation to a different area or a change in job or family circumstances which makes it difficult for them to attend a Lodge meeting.
- Sometimes these circumstances change again, making a return to Freemasonry a possibility.
- Re-engaging with these Brethren can often lead to a consideration to re-join a Lodge.
- During the Covid-19 pandemic many Lodges re-engaged with former members and awakened their interest in re-joining.
- Maintain contact with a member who resigns due to a change in personal circumstances; they may be able to re-join at a later date.
- Opportunities include:

  - the Lodge Almoner could keep in touch with them, sending birthdays cards, etc
  - they could be supplied with information concerning the activities of the Lodge
  - they could be sent Provincial newsletters
  - they could be sent copies of Freemasonry Today
  - they could be invited to social functions
  - their wife or partner may be eligible to remain a member of an Association
  - they will continue to be eligible for Masonic relief grants from the Masonic Charitable Foundation.

- Some Provinces are encouraging their Lodges to locate Unattached Freemasons within their area and to invite them to a Lodge meeting, to re-kindle their interest in the Craft.

RULES GOVERNING ATTENDANCE BY UNATTACHED FREEMASONS

Rule 127 of the Book of Constitutions governs the attendance at Lodge by Unattached Freemasons. Since 9th September 2020, the rule has stated:

> **127.** In the case of a Brother who has ceased to be a subscribing member of every Lodge of which he has at any time been a member, the following provisions shall have effect, viz.:
>
> (i) If he comes within the provisions of this Rule by reason of his exclusion under Rule 148 or Rule 181, he shall not be permitted to attend any Lodge or Lodge of Instruction until he again becomes a subscribing member of a Lodge.
>
> (ii) If he comes within the provisions of this Rule by reason of his expulsion from the Craft or by reason of his resignation from the Craft under Rule 183A or Rule 277A, his right to attend any Lodge or Lodge of Instruction shall be forfeited.
>
> (iii) In any other case he shall not be permitted to attend any one Lodge more than once until he again becomes a subscribing member of a Lodge, and upon such one attendance he shall append the word 'unattached' to his signature in the attendance book, stating therein the name and number of the Lodge of which he was last a subscribing member. Notwithstanding the foregoing provisions of this paragraph he shall be permitted to attend one, but only one, Lodge on not more than two further occasions with a view to becoming a subscribing member of that Lodge; provided that (a) the Master of that Lodge shall have confirmed to the Secretary in writing that such is the purpose of his subsequent visit, and (b) his final visit to such Lodge shall take place not later than one year after the first visit.
>
> Nothing in this Rule shall preclude the attendance of a Brother at any Lodge of which he is an Honorary Member.

Therefore, an Unattached Freemason who has not been excluded, expelled or resigned from the Craft, may attend any Lodge once. He may attend one Lodge up to three times if he is considering joining that Lodge and providing the three visits occur within a twelve-month period.

The rationale for this latter provision is, in the words of the President of the Board of General Purposes, RW Bro. Geoffrey Dearing, to:

> *"help him make a reasoned judgment concerning the Lodge he considers joining. Only being able to visit the Lodge on one occasion is unlikely to give a proper chance of making that judgment. The members of the Lodge, which the brother is considering joining, will wish to know something about him so that they in turn can make their own judgment on whether the individual is right for the Lodge. Even a small Lodge would have difficulty in making a decision from a single visit by the potential joining member."*
>
> First Rising, 6th July 2020

The Members' Pathway: *Level 3*

RETRIEVE> Understand Reasons for Losses > *Lessons Learned from Losses*

As in all things, if you want your Lodge to grow and improve, you ought to learn the lessons from the past. This is why we encourage Lodges to conduct a Lodge review at intervals, and to update their Lodge plans in the light of new information.

If you understand the REAL reasons why members have resigned from your Lodge, you at least have the opportunity to address any underlying problems and plan solutions.

Regrettably some Lodges seem to blame resignations on the leaving member (eg, "*Well, he wasn't really right for us*") and are unwilling to address the cause. This doesn't change the reality and only delays the inevitable.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- As the Lodge Membership Team collate the information from several resignations to identify any patterns or trends.
- Examine historical data to identify any periods when losses accelerated and whether there were any significant events that may have contributed to this decline.
- Seek feedback from the Province about exit interviews that have been conducted, accepting that this will be anonymous so as not to identify individual former members.
- If many members resign in a relatively short period, conduct a review of the Lodge and be willing to adapt to make the Lodge more attractive and engaging.
- Update your Lodge development plan to address and resolve the root causes behind resignations.
- If your Lodge is in decline and at risk of closure, consider alternative futures including approaches to rejuvenation such as "adaptation."
- For example:
  - Aligning the Lodge to a special interest (such as a school, hobby, youth or service organisation) to attract new members ("adoption" of a special interest).
  - Introducing a group of enthusiastic joining members (such as Provincial Stewards) to refresh the Lodge's management ("adoption" by a new management team).
  - Rather than founding a new Lodge, adopting an existing Lodge and transitioning it to a new membership ("adoption" by a new membership).
- If the Lodge is intending to close, plan in advance so that members can investigate and transfer to new Lodges before the Lodge votes to return its warrant.

SUGGESTIONS FOR METROPOLITAN / PROVINCIAL / DISTRICT GRAND LODGES

- Monitor and review the results of exit interviews to identify any patterns or underlying themes in the reasons members resign.
- Conduct a member engagement survey to ask your membership about their experience of Freemasonry and their levels of satisfaction.
- Decide on a policy for giving feedback to Lodges, to determine whether a Lodge should receive feedback specifically from its own members or whether all Lodges should receive generic feedback.

- Ensure all feedback is anonymous and cannot reveal the identity of the source.
- Build Provincial initiatives to address the underlying themes behind resignations.
- Encourage Lodges which experience many resignations to conduct more in-depth reviews and build more focused plans to rejuvenate the Lodge.
- Offer Lodges at risk of closure a package of support and assistance to rejuvenate the Lodge.
- Encourage Lodges that are intending to close to plan in advance so that members can transfer to new Lodges before they return their warrant.
- Appoint a member of your team who is an experienced Almoner to look after the needs of any member (and their dependents) who do not transfer to a new Lodge.
- Encourage members to be open to change and to look beyond their personal wishes and preferences to the long-term best interests and health of the Lodge.
- Share experiences and learning with other Provinces and be willing to seek their ideas to help you.

WHAT NEXT?

This element completes the circle as shown in the Members' Pathway diagram.

- *All good planning processes involve a review, during which lessons are learned, followed by development of the next plan.*
- *At intervals of every two to three years, or whenever there is a significant change, event or concern in the Lodge, revisit Lodge Planning.*
- *Begin with another Lodge Review, making full use of the lessons learned.*

Following this continuous planning loop approach will mean your Lodge will always stays fresh, relevant, and attractive to new and existing members.